Before Kasturirangan could process it, the Kerala Police arrested me, on 30 November 1994. Having been booked in a criminal case, my employment with ISRO stood suspended. Anything about my continuance or my resignation was in suspended animation till the case came to a logical end. The interrogators of IB later had a field day flashing my letter seeking voluntary retirement as a bid to escape the spy case.

'Here is proof that you wanted to run away before we came,' an IB officer had said.

'Please call me anything but an idiot,' I told him. 'If I had done something wrong, do you think I would submit my resignation and leave the letter as evidence in your hands?'

The IB man had not got it, but the CBI later found merit in my argument.

As for the resignation letter dated 1 November 1994, the IB chose not to read my footnote: Incidentally, you may kindly recall my discussion with you during August 1994 and my request to seek voluntary retirement after the PSLV launch. And you had kindly agreed to my request to be relieved after the launch.

The CBI later upheld this point.

But now, with my arrest, the ISRO spy case just had its big villain. What was a case of a Maldivian tourist's overstay in Trivandrum less than a month ago, had become a potboiler of spies, rocketry and two Indian space scientists who plotted to sell the nation's secret to Pakistan!

Hardly one-and-a-half month into the successful launch of its first polar satellite launch vehicle, ISRO's champagne had not cooled enough when the police came for me. The conspirators must have clinked glasses.